

## The Saints will pray when we cannot. St Paisius the Great. June 19.

St. Paisius the Great attained such holiness that God listened to his prayers for a monk who had completely abandoned the Christian life. Surely we all know someone, one person or many, who are in dire straits, because of some condition of long-standing duration, and perhaps we are despondent about it. We should be edified and encouraged, AND be spurred to action by his story.

Below is the most important part of his life and a reason why the prayers of St. Paisius will comfort anyone troubled by an overwhelming problem affecting a loved one. Perhaps a son, daughter, husband, or any loved one has apostasized, and even become an atheist or even hateful towards God, or New Age, or is help captive to whatever other delusion afflicts people by the devil's provocations. Perhaps someone is living a heedless life, or is an addict, or (something more and more common in our day) a victim of bizarre gender dysphoria, depression, anxiety, suicidal ideation or mental illness. The list of the ways in which human beings are tormented by the combination of their passions, environment, and the demons goes on and on.

A certain monk left the monastic life and started fornicating and living with a woman, and even worse than this, since this woman hated and blasphemed Christ, under her influence, he was not only a fornicator, but also a blasphemer and hateful to God. He was still living in the desert cell, although he often sinned with the woman. By God's grace, some monks came to his cell, and the former monk and great sinner was struck with conscience and begged them to ask Abba Paisius to pray for him.

This disgraced monk was not able to extricate himself from his sin; he needed help! He was able to recognize this, and he even had a pang of conscience regarding his sin, but he was not able to change on his own accord.

Sometimes we judge someone because we think the reason they don't change is that they're not trying hard enough or they're not serious, and we believe the ultimate reason why they remain in their sin is that they're not exercising their will to change. Unfortunately, it can happen that when a person sins, depending on the nature and length of time of these sins, that Satan greatly weakens their will by long provocation and manipulation, and although they are *able to desire* to change, *they are quite unable without help*. God knows who these people are. All we need to know is that these people exist. We may give them instruction, support, and even rebuke, but they are quite unable to change without divine grace, which is something that we do not have the power to give or even ask for adequately, as those who fought the good fight and finished a good course can do.

St. Paisius began to pray fervently for the monk, and the Lord Jesus Christ appeared to him, promising that the monk would be delivered from his sinful afflictions. Grace moves in mysterious ways that we cannot fathom or understand. The genesis of the monk's repentance was that the woman died, and he returned to the fathers, weeping and repenting of his sin. No doubt, many other things had to happen to support him when he began to do works of repentance.

**May I be so bold as to ask you to pray to St. Paisius every day and beg him to help those whom you love, who appear to be totally lost? We also should pray for our loved ones, but we are weak, and when we ask the Saints to pray with us, and for us, we are comforted, and the prayer is stronger.**

**Therefore, sing his Troparion and his Kontakion every day, and then ask in simplicity for him to pray for your loved one.**

It's not complicated. You could say, "Holy Father Paisius, pray that my son would be restored to the church." Or even simpler: "Holy Paisius, help my boy to be saved!" You should also ask him to help you not to lose heart, and to have wisdom and endurance. You do not need to be eloquent, but you need to be persistent, and pray to St. Paisius that he will pray for your loved one every day.

Don't lose heart! You cannot do this on your own. Take comfort in the life of St. Paisius, which demonstrates that his prayers are indeed very powerful.

Here are three other interesting details from the long and productive life of this holy father.

Our venerable father Paisios was consecrated to God after his mother had a vision from an angel. This sounds like a rather strong endorsement! He began his monastic life in the Nitria desert in Egypt, along the upper Nile (Northern Egypt, West of the Nile). He knew many great saints of that era such as Abba Pambo (who made him among them was his first spiritual father), St John Colobos, Poemen the Great, and Paul of Thebes.

One time he was transported to paradise while in ecstasy, and was granted the ability to eat no food whatsoever except the holy Communion that he received on Sundays. Because he lived in the desert and there were long distances between monks, daily Divine liturgy was very rare. He did this for 70 years! He felt no hunger because divine grace strengthened him.

Holy Fr Paisios the Great, pray to God for us!

St Paisios the Great June 19

**Troparion — Tone 4** (*Podoben*<sup>i</sup>: “Be quick to anticipate...”)<sup>ii</sup>

Fervently, let us honor the God-bearer Paΐsios, / an Angel in the flesh, the crown of Monastics, / an incorporeal man and a citizen of Heaven, / who celebrates with us, / granting grace to all who rejoice in his memory.

**Kontakion — Tone 8** (*Podoben*: “O Victorious (Champion) Leader...”)<sup>iii</sup>

Let us, the faithful, sing praises to the godly-wise Paΐsios, / the adornment of the desert, equal of the Angels, the friend of Christ, and the glory of Monastic Saints. / Let us cry to him: “Rejoice, O Father Paΐsios.”

**A simple prayer to St. Paisios.**

“Holy Father Paisios, I do not have the strength to pray in such a way that brings divine grace upon those I love. I don’t have the wisdom to know what to say, or the endurance to continue because of my daily pain. I beg thee to pray for the Servants of God *N.*, that they would find their way to full repentance and restoration, and also for me that I would have wisdom and endurance, and that my actions will help them obtain full repentance, and not hinder them in any way.”

Document: <https://www.orthodox.net/posts/the-saints-will-pray-when-we-cannot-st-paisius-the-great-june-19>

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<sup>i</sup> A “podoben” is a special melody. The church has many. But

<sup>ii</sup> The full phrase, “Be quick to anticipate, O ye martyrs, the crowns of incorruption and life which are bestowed upon you by the Lord,” Audio (Byzantine melody): <https://youtu.be/11GkBueNnoU?si=aSq1pezBpn2rhf-H> I have not been able to find audio of the Russian melody online.

<sup>iii</sup> This is the familiar melody from the Akathist to the Theotokos. I think it is much easier to fit the words to the Russian melody.